

Streamflow

Katie Markovich, EPS 522/ ENVS 423L (Fall 2025)

Housekeeping

- Problem sets #1-4 will be returned asap this week
- PS #5 assigned Thursday, but not due until October 16
- Streamflow concepts will not be on Midterm, but will be on Final
- Guest lecture on Thursday followed by exam review
- Midterm exam next Tuesday
- You will need a basic calculator for the exam!

Latent and Sensible Heat

Latent Heat (LE): energy absorbed or released as part of a phase change (condensation releases energy, evaporation absorbs energy). Called latent because it's **hidden**, i.e., cannot be measured, like temperature.

$$E = K_E \cdot v_a \cdot (e_s - e_a)$$

$$LE = \rho_w \cdot \lambda_v \cdot E$$

Sensible Heat (H): Energy exchange that you can **sense** because it leads to a change in temperature.

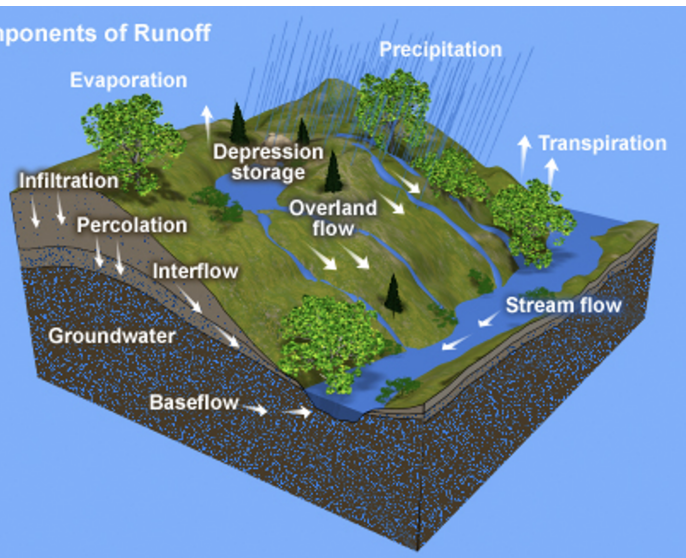
$$H = K_H \cdot v(z_m) \cdot [T_s - T(z_m)]$$

Learning Objectives

- 1 Stream response to water input
- 2 Basics of stream gaging
- 3 Hydrograph separation purpose and methods
- 4 Runoff-generation mechanisms
- 5 Stream network and routing
- 6 Rainfall runoff-modeling

Runoff-Generation Mechanisms

Components of Runoff



- 1 Channel precipitation
- 2 Overland flow
- 3 Subsurface event flow

Channel Precipitation

Precipitation that falls directly on stream channel.

$$W_{cp} = W \cdot A_{cn}$$

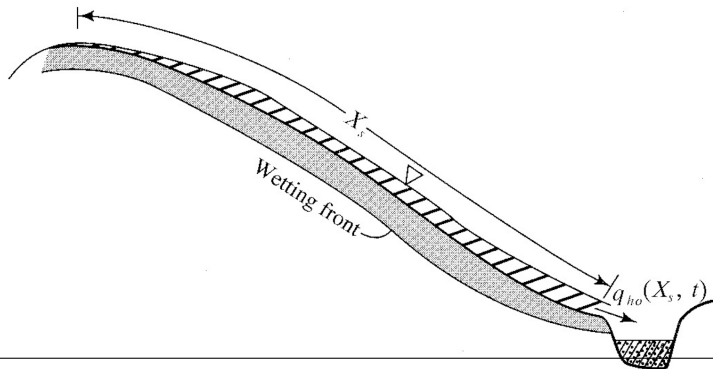
where W is the average water input rate across the drainage area and A_{cn} is the area of the channel network, typically a small fraction (1%) of the total drainage area. Despite the small area, it can be a significant component of q_{pk} and event flow.

Hortonian Overland Flow

"Saturated from above" or "infiltration-excess" overland flow.

$$q_{ho}(t) = W_{eff}(t) - f(t)$$

where $f(t)$ is the infiltration rate, governed by the saturated hydraulic conductivity (K_h^*) of the surface layer.



Hortonian Overland Flow

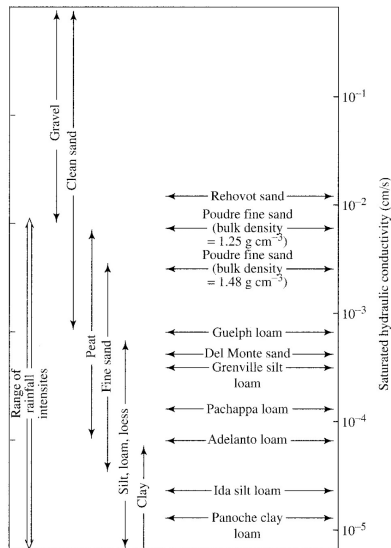
Hortonian overland flow was thought to be the principal runoff-generating mechanism from the 1930s through the 1950s, but it turns out infiltration-excess runoff only occurs in situations of intense rainfall or arid systems.



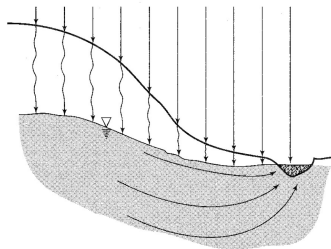
Wait, what is hydraulic conductivity?

Hydraulic conductivity (K), having units of L/T , is the ability of a porous medium to transmit water.

Saturated hydraulic conductivity is used for unsaturated porous media, like soils, which can have varying degrees of saturation, and K depends nonlinearly on saturation.

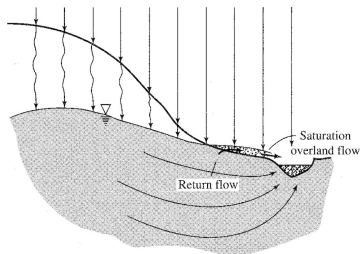


Saturation Overland Flow



(a)

Also called Dunnian overland flow, where water input infiltrates and saturated zone "breaks out" of the land surface.

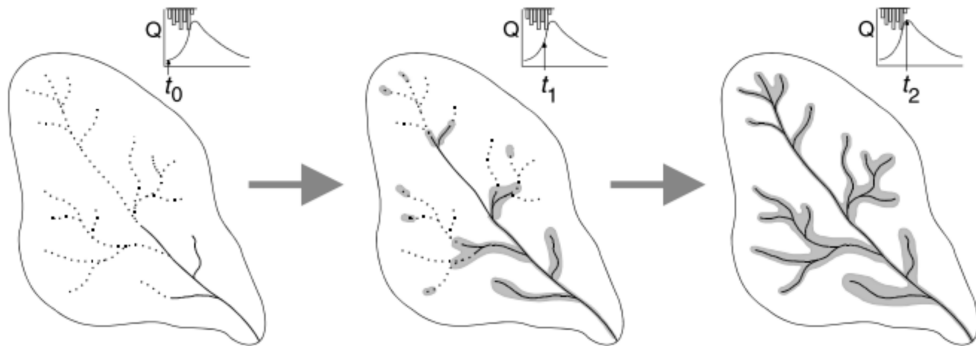


(b)

First observed in humid regions with shallow water table and gaining streams.

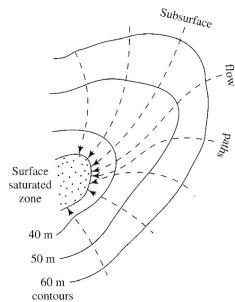
Variable Source Area (VSA)

A concept that saturation excess is the dominant contributor to runoff and extent of areas saturated from below varies widely, dependent on antecedent wetness.

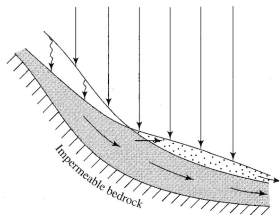


Issues?

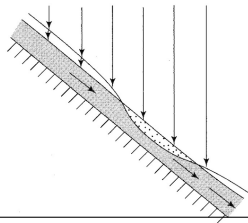
Mechanisms for Saturation Excess



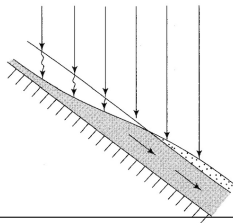
(a)



(b)



(c)



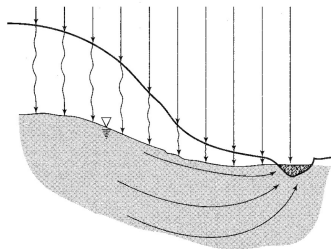
(d)

- a. convergence
- b. slope break
- c. local thinning out of soil
- d. saturation excess

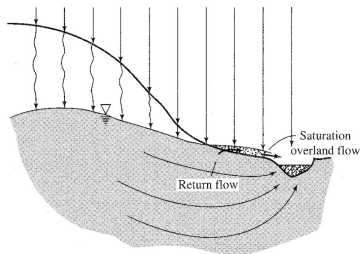
Subsurface Event (Storm) Flow

- Subsurface contribution to the response hydrograph that is hydraulically distinct from baseflow.
- Often referred to as **interflow**
- Can occur in the **saturated** and/or **unsaturated** zone.
- Likely the cause for the "Old Water Paradox."

Groundwater Mounding



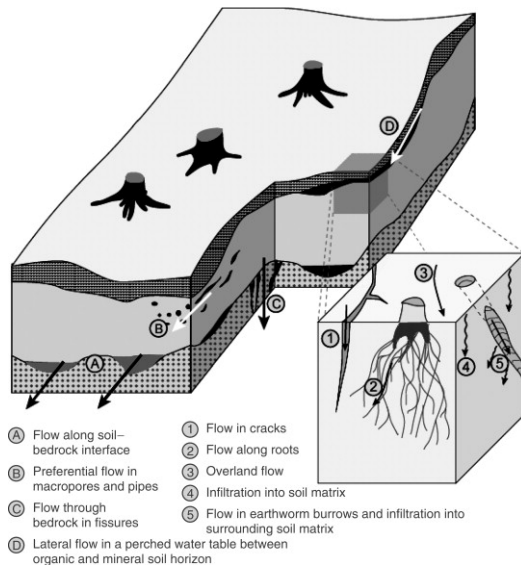
(a)



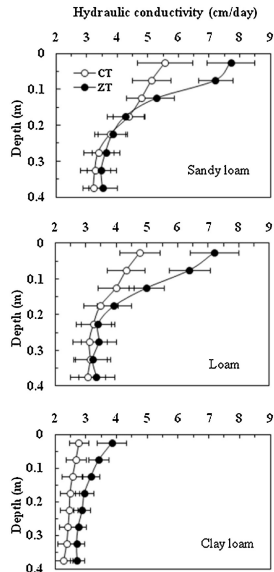
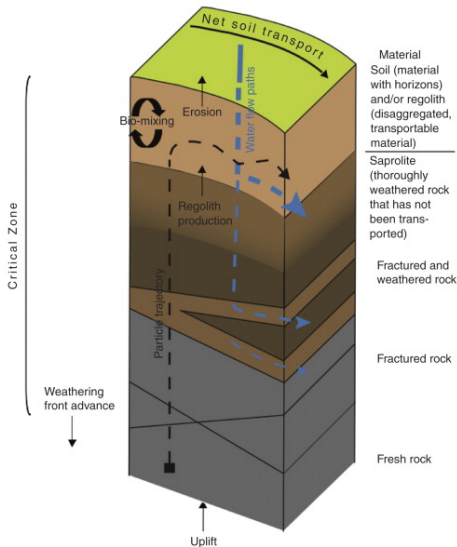
(b)

The same process that leads to saturation excess overland flow (infiltration of event water that leads to a rise in the saturated zone) also leads to larger subsurface contributions to streamflow due to steeper hydraulic gradients.

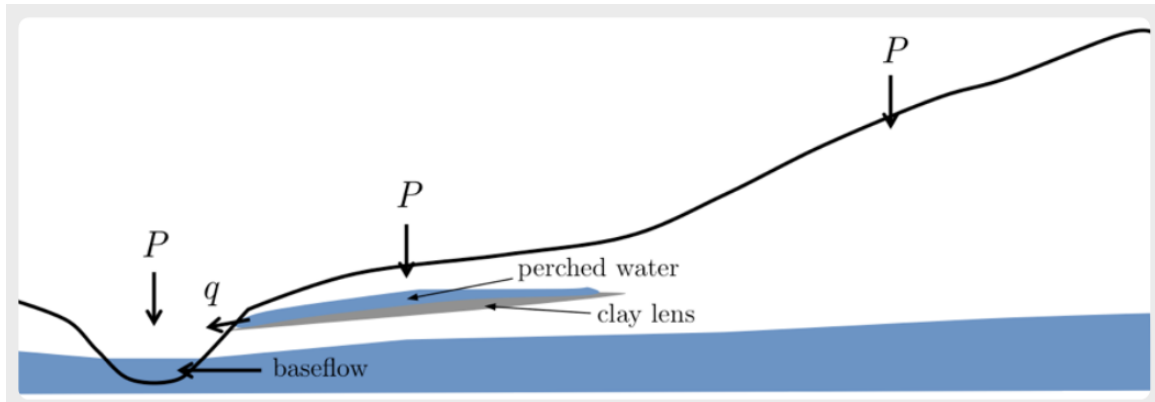
Perched Saturated Zones



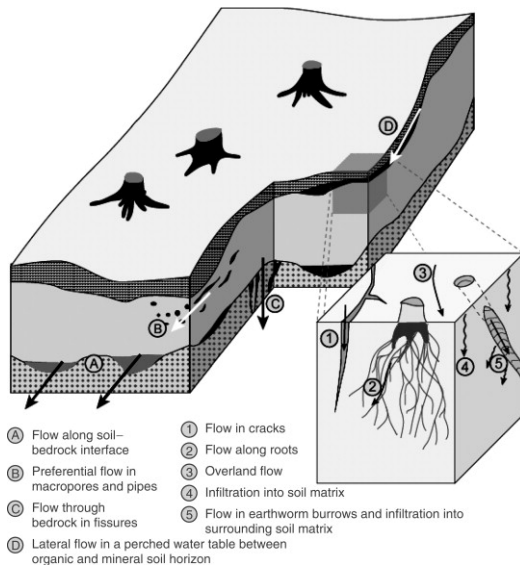
Hydraulic Conductivity vs Depth



Perched Saturated Zones

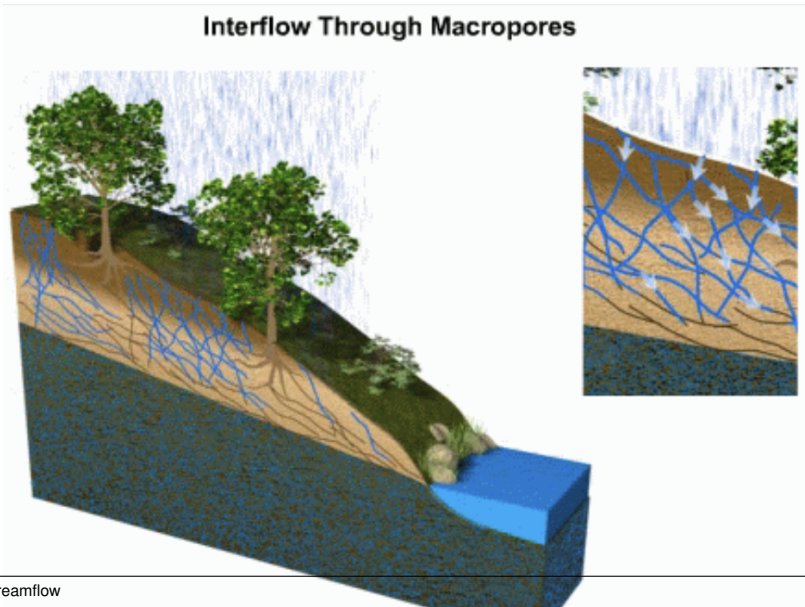


Macropore Flow



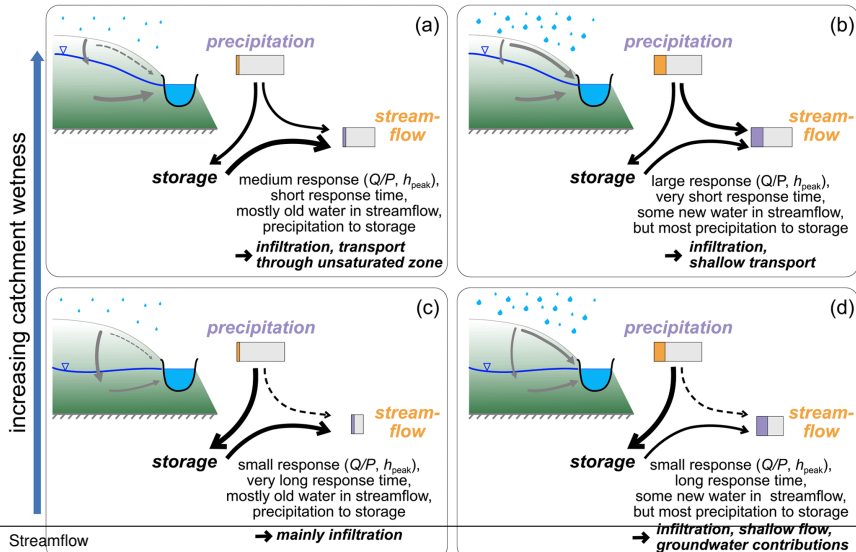
Macropore Flow

Interflow Through Macropores



Antecedent Wetness

Knapp et al. (2025)



Runoff-generation Mechanisms

Soils Permeability Slope
shallow lower gentle



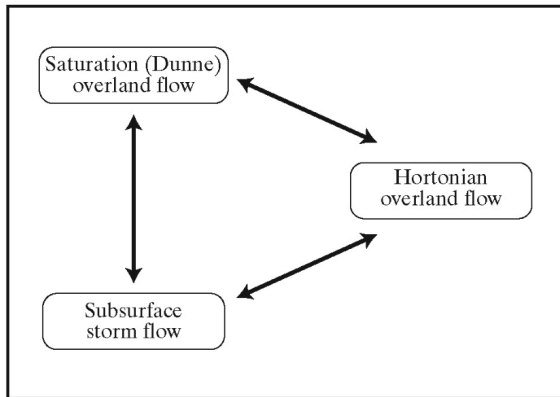
deep



higher



steep



Climate

humid



arid

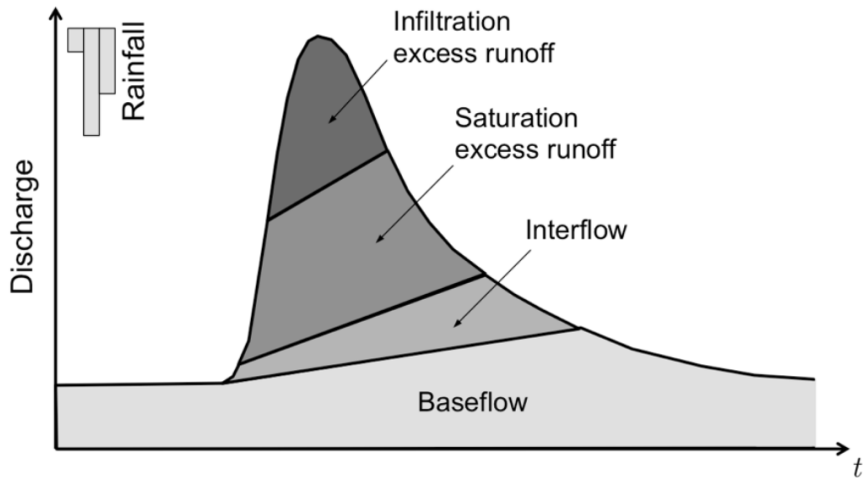
Vegetation

dense



none

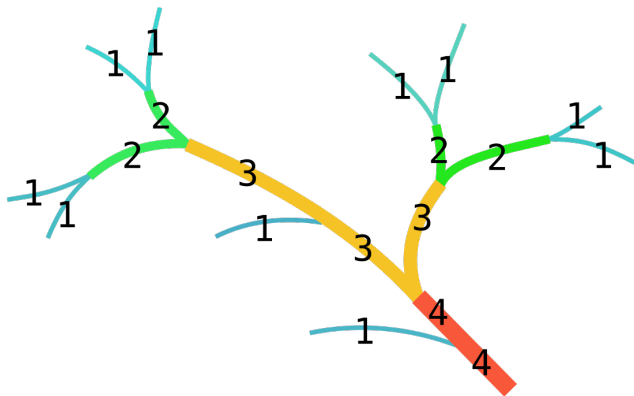
Old Water Paradox, revisited



Stream Network

Strahler (1975) stream order is most common framework for quantitatively describing stream networks.

- Tributaries have an order of 1
- Confluence of two 1st order streams is a 2nd order stream, and so on
- Confluence of a lower order stream does not change order



Stream Order Exercise

Stream Network

Drainage density is the total length of streams ($\sum L$) draining an area (A_d)

$$D_d = \frac{\sum L}{A_d}$$

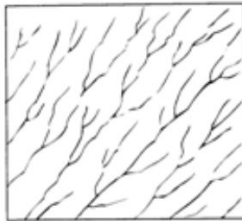
Relation of D_d to:

- 1 average precipitation:
- 2 soils and bedrock:

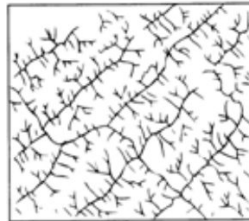
Stream Patterns



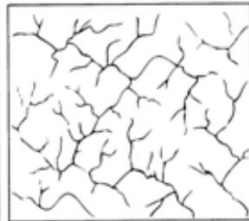
(A) Dendritic



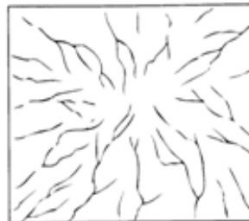
(B) Parallel



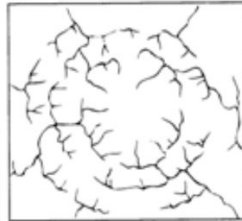
(C) Trellis



(D) Rectangular



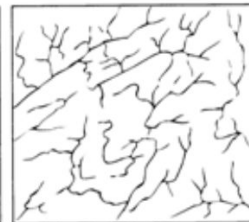
(E) Radial



(F) Annular



(G) Multibasinal



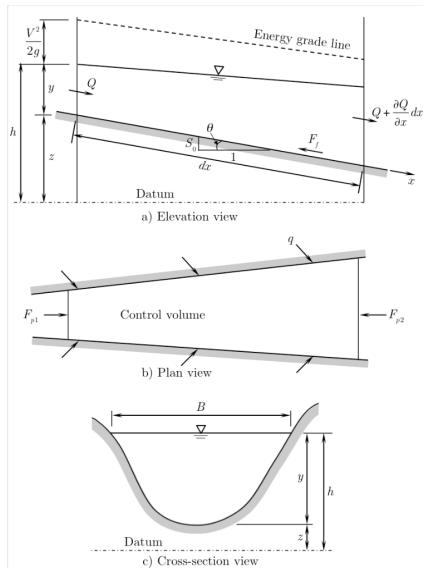
(H) Contorted

Hydraulic Streamflow Routing

We can estimate discharge at any point along a stream channel, assuming flow is effectively 1-dimensional in the x-direction with the continuity equation:

$$\frac{\partial A}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial Q}{\partial x} - q = 0$$

where A is cross-sectional area, t is time, Q is discharge, and q is inflows/outflows to the stream channel.

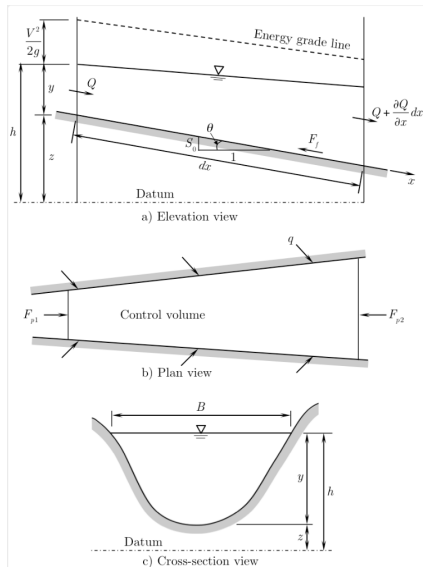


Hydraulic Streamflow Routing

$$\frac{\partial A}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial Q}{\partial x} - q = 0$$

This is a partial differential equation (PDE), whose solution requires specifying:

- initial conditions (i.e., starting A and Q along the channel)
- boundary conditions (i.e., Q inflows to the channel)



Hydraulic Streamflow Routing

Because the continuity equation has 2 unknowns (Q , A), we have to apply an independent constraint to help solve it. We do so using the conservation of momentum:

$$\frac{1}{A} \frac{\partial Q}{\partial t} + \frac{1}{A} \frac{\partial}{\partial x} \left(\frac{Q^2}{A} \right) + g \frac{\partial y}{\partial x} - g(S_0 - S_f) = 0$$

where g is gravitational acceleration, y is water depth (related to A), S_0 is the channel bed slope, S_f is the head loss per unit length of channel

Saint-Venant Equations

$$\frac{\partial A}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial Q}{\partial x} - q = 0$$

$$\frac{1}{A} \frac{\partial Q}{\partial t} + \frac{1}{A} \frac{\partial}{\partial x} \left(\frac{Q^2}{A} \right) + g \frac{\partial y}{\partial x} - g(S_0 - S_f) = 0$$

Together, the continuity and conservation of momentum equations are called the **Saint-Venant Equations** or **Shallow Water Equations** for 1-D, unsteady flow in a channel. These are typically solved numerically by discretizing the channel and approximating ∂ with Δ

Steady flow with no lateral inflow

$$\frac{\partial A}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial Q}{\partial x} - q = 0$$

$$\frac{1}{A} \frac{\partial Q}{\partial t} + \frac{1}{A} \frac{\partial}{\partial x} \left(\frac{Q^2}{A} \right) + g \frac{\partial y}{\partial x} - g(S_0 - S_f) = 0$$

Steady, uniform flow with no lateral inflow

$$\frac{\partial A}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial Q}{\partial x} - q = 0$$

$$\frac{1}{A} \frac{\partial Q}{\partial t} + \frac{1}{A} \frac{\partial}{\partial x} \left(\frac{Q^2}{A} \right) + g \frac{\partial y}{\partial x} - g(S_0 - S_f) = 0$$

"Head losses from friction balance the elevation head gradient"

Hydraulic Streamflow Routing

For steady, uniform flow with no lateral inflows, the Saint-Venant equations can be simplified to the so-called Mannings Equation:

$$Q = \frac{1}{n} A^{2/3} S_0^{1/2}$$

where n is the Mannings roughness coefficient describing resistance to flow.

Roughness Zone	Shallow Manning's n	Deep Manning's n
Bays and Estuaries	0.060	0.030
Concrete Channel	0.060	0.030
Emergent Aquatic Vegetation	0.300	0.200
Freshwater Marshes	0.300	0.200
Hardwood Conifer Mixed	0.400	0.200
Mangrove Swamps	0.300	0.200
Natural Channel	0.100	0.080
Open Land	0.150	0.040
Paved Road	0.014	0.012
Pine Flatwoods	0.300	0.200
Reservoirs	0.300	0.200
Saltwater Marshes	0.300	0.200
Shrub and Brushland	0.300	0.150
Upland Coniferous Forest	0.400	0.200
Wet Prairies	0.300	0.200
Wetland Forested Mixed	0.400	0.200

Shallow and deep Manning's roughness coefficient (n) for 2D surface model (based on Chow [31] and TR-55 [29]).

Simplifications

$$\frac{1}{A} \frac{\partial Q}{\partial t} + \frac{1}{A} \frac{\partial}{\partial x} \left(\frac{Q^2}{A} \right) + g \frac{\partial y}{\partial x} - g(S_o - S_f) = 0$$

Local
acceleration
term

Convective
acceleration
term

Pressure
force
term

Gravity
force
term

Friction
force
term

$$\frac{\partial V}{\partial t} + V \frac{\partial V}{\partial x} + g \frac{\partial y}{\partial x} - g(S_o - S_f) = 0$$



- Dynamic: good for rapid/abrupt change in conditions like hydraulic jumps, shock waves, etc. but overkill in most hydro application.
- Diffusive: neglects inertial term and assumes wave spreads diffusively as it travels.
- Kinematic: simplest, neglecting pressure and inertial terms, assumes gravity and friction are dominant forces.

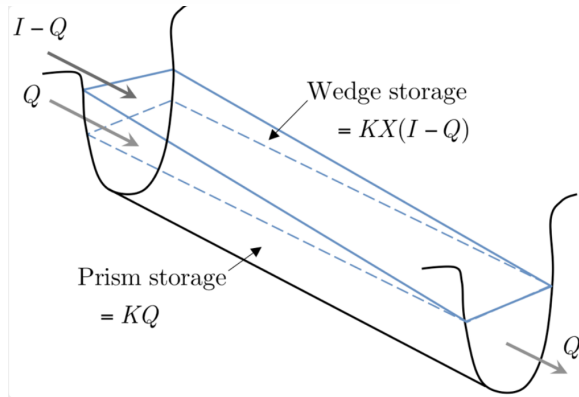
Hydrologic Routing

Conservation of mass at the stream reach scale (i.e., lumped rather than discretized).

$$O_t = \left(\frac{\Delta t - 2KX}{2K(1-X) + \Delta t} \right) I_t + \left(\frac{\Delta t + 2KX}{2K(1-X) + \Delta t} \right) I_{t-1} + \left(\frac{2K(1-X) - \Delta t}{2K(1-X) + \Delta t} \right) O_{t-1}$$

Muskingum Streamflow Routing

where O is outflow, t is time, X is a weighting coefficient (0 to 0.5, typically 0.3 for natural streams) and K is the travel time of a flood wave through the reach.



Rainfall-Runoff Modeling Methods

- 1 Empirical/Conceptual
- 2 Physically-based

SCS Curve Number

Soil conservation service (SCS) curve number approach is an empirical approach to estimate precipitation excess (P_e), equivalent to event runoff, for a "normal" wetness condition.

$$P_e = \frac{(P - 0.2 \cdot S_{max})^2}{P + 0.8 \cdot S_{max}}$$

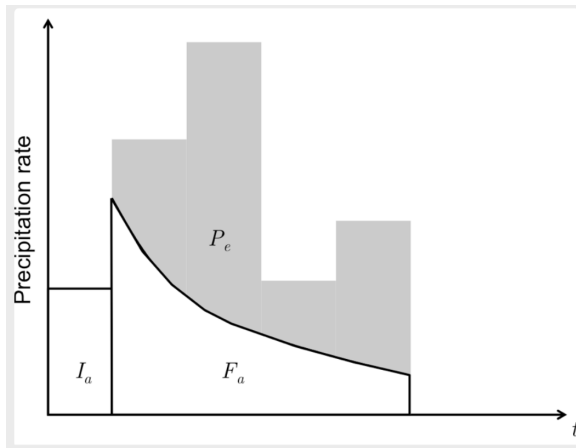
$$S_{max} = \frac{25,400}{CN} - 254$$

where CN is the curve number (0-100) based on hydrologic soil group and land cover type.

Cover			Hydrologic Soil Group			
Land Use	Treatment or Practice	Hydrologic Condition	A	B	C	D
Fallows	Straight row		77	86	91	94
Row crops	Straight row	Poor Good	72 67	81 78	88 85	91 89
	Contoured	Poor Good	70 65	79 75	84 82	88 86
	Contoured and terraced	Poor Good	66 62	74 71	80 78	82 81
Small grain	Straight row	Poor Good	65 63	76 75	84 83	88 87
	Contoured	Poor Good	63 61	74 73	82 81	85 84
	Contoured and terraced	Poor Good	61 59	72 70	79 78	82 81
Close-seeded legumes or rotation meadow	Straight row	Poor Good	66 58	77 72	85 81	89 85
	Contoured	Poor Good	64 55	75 69	83 78	85 83
	Contoured and terraced	Poor Good	63 51	73 67	80 76	83 80
Pasture or range	Contoured	Poor Fair Good	68 49 39	79 69 61	86 79 74	89 84 80
		Poor Fair Good	47 25 6	67 59 35	81 75 70	88 83 79
Meadow		Good	30	58	71	78
Woods		Poor Fair Good	45 36 25	66 60 55	77 73 70	83 79 77
Farmsteads			59	74	82	86
Roads (dirt) (hard surface)			72 74	82 84	87 90	89 92

Curve Numbers

What kind of runoff-generation mechanism does this resemble?

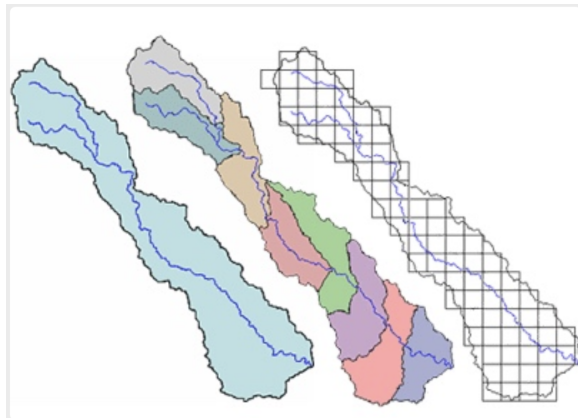


What major factor does this not account for?

Physically-based Rainfall-Runoff Modeling

Simulate runoff based on physical processes (such as infiltration, evaporation, unsaturated zone moisture redistribution, recharge, and groundwater flow).

There are a dozen of "physically-based" models available differing in their discretization strategy, process inclusion and representation, etc.



Physically-based Rainfall-Runoff Modeling

Name	Type	Channel Routing	Overland Flow
SWAT	Semi-Distributed	Muskingum or Variable Storage	SCS Curve Number
PRMS	Lumped/Distributed	Muskingum or Mass Balance	Mass Balance (Hortonian, Dunnian, Interflow)
HEC-HMS	Semi-distributed	Muskingum, Kinematic Wave, and many more...	Unit Hydrograph, Kinematic/Diffusive Wave
MODFLOW6	Distributed	Mass Balance, Kinematic/Diffusive Wave	n/a, Kinematic/Diffusive Wave
ParFlow	Distributed	Kinematic/Diffusive Wave	Kinematic/Diffusive Wave

Precipitation-Runoff Modeling System

